

Herbs That Calm the Spirit

- Tranquilize and calm the mind and emotions
- Shen resides in the Heart, and the soul resides in the Liver
- Shen disturbances are an emotional disorder.

General Characteristics of Sedative Herbs that Calm the Shen (Spirit)

- Material: minerals and shells
- Taste: sweet
- Thermal property: neutral, cold
- Channels entered: Heart, Liver
- Therapeutic actions: sedate the Heart, calm the Shen; they are more suitable for excess-type Shen disturbances.

General Characteristics of Nourishing Herbs that Calm the Shen (Spirit)

- Material: plant substance
- Taste: sweet
- Thermal property: neutral
- Channels entered: Heart, Spleen, Liver
- Therapeutic actions: nourish the Heart, calm the Shen. They are most effective for deficient-type Shen disturbances.

Name	Similarities	Differences
Mineral Sedative Herbs that Calm the Shen		
Ci Shi (Magnetitum)	Sedate the Heart, calm the Shen	Anchors Liver yang, improves hearing and vision, and stops wheezing
Long Gu (Os Draconis)		Calms Liver, anchors floating yang; prevents leakage of fluids
Nourishing Herbs that Calm the Shen		
Suan Zao Ren (Semen Zizyphi Spinosae)	Nourish the Heart, calm the Shen	Nourishes Heart, Liver, and Kidney to calm deficiency-type Shen disturbances, stops perspiration
Bai Zi Ren (Semen Platycladi)		Eases excessive worrying that has caused Heart blood deficiency, and relieves constipation
Yuan Zhi (Radix Polygalae)		Eliminates phlegm obstructing the Heart
He Huan Pi (Cortex Albiziae)		Soothes Liver qi stagnation, invigorates blood circulation and reduces swelling
Ye Jiao Teng (Caulis Polygoni Multiflori)		Opens channels and collaterals, dispels wind

Mineral Sedative Herbs that Calm the Shen**Cí Shí 磁石**

- *Magnetitum*
- English: magnetite
- Properties: acrid, salty, cold
- Channels: Heart, Liver, Kidney

Actions and Indications**Actions: Anchors yang and calms the spirit**

Indications: for restlessness, palpitations, insomnia or tremors, especially in patients with yin deficiency and ascendant yang

Actions: Tonifies the Kidneys, augments the Liver and improves hearing and vision.

Indications: for impaired hearing or deafness, tinnitus, or visual disturbances due to Liver and Kidney deficiency.

- Insomnia, palpitations, anxiety, or epilepsy: Zhu Sha (Formula: Ci zhu wan), Shi Jue Ming, Bai Shao, Sheng Di
- Tinnitus, hearing loss, cataracts, and blurred vision due to Liver and Kidney yin deficiency: Shu Di, Shan Zhu Yu, Wu Wei Zi (formula: Er ming zuo ci wan)

Actions: Aids the Kidneys in grasping the qi

Indications: for chronic asthma due to the Kidneys' failure to grasp the qi: Dai Zhe Shi, Wu Wei Zi, Hu Tao Rou

Main Actions:

- Anchors liver yang and calms the Shen
- Improves hearing and brightens eyes
- Aids the Kidney in grasping Qi

Dosage: 10-30 grams in decoction, 1-3 grams of Ci Shi when taken as powder or pills. Crush and pre-decoct it to maximize the extraction of active components.

Cautions:

Because Ci Shi is difficult to digest when taken as powder or pills, excessive or prolonged intake in these forms is contraindicated.

Review questions

- What channels does Ci Shi enter?
- What herb can be used to treat tinnitus and blurred vision due to liver and kidney deficiency?
- What herbs aid the Kidney in grasping qi?

Lóng Gǔ 龙骨

- *Os Draconis*
- English: dragon bone (fossil), fossilized animal bones.
- Properties: sweet, astringent, neutral

- Channels: Heart, Liver

Actions and Indications

Actions: Calms the liver and anchors floating yang

Indications: for irritability, short temper, dizziness and vertigo, and muscular rigidity due to yin deficiency with yang rising: Mu Li, Bai Shao, Dai Zhe Shi (formula: Zhen gan xi feng tang)

Actions: Sedates and calms the Shen (spirit)

Indications: for restless Shen or Shen disturbance leading to insomnia, restlessness, forgetfulness, anxiety, palpitations. Use unprocessed Long Gu.

Actions: Astringent to consolidate and prevent leakage of fluids.

Indications: for loss of fluids due to deficiency, including spermatorrhea, night sweats, spontaneous sweating, nocturnal emissions, vaginal discharge, and uterine bleeding.

- Shen disturbance: Zhu Sha, Yuan Zhi, Suan Zao Ren
- Spermatorrhea, low back pain, or tinnitus: Mu Li, Sha Yuan Zhi Qian Shi (formula: Jin suo gu jing wan)
- Enuresis: Sang Piao Xiao, Fu Pen Zi, Yi Zhi Ren
- Spontaneous or night sweating: Huang Qi, Mu Li, Wu Wei Zi
- White vaginal discharge: Cang Zhu, Yi Yi Ren, Fu Ling

Actions: Promotes healing of sores or eczema

Indication: for non-healing ulcerations or sores, eczema or rashes; Apply calcinated Long Gu topically as a powder.

Main Actions:

- Calms the Liver and anchors rising yang
- Sedates and calms the Shen
- Astringent to prevent and consolidate leakage

Dosage: 15-30 grams for unprocessed Long Gu; 9-15 grams for the calcinated form.

Crush and pre-decoct Long Gu to enhance the extraction of active components.

Calcinating (Duan Long Gu) enhances its binding effect to prevent the loss of body fluids, as in the treatment of spermatorrhea, diarrhea, and excessive vaginal discharge.

Cautions:

Use of Long Gu is contraindicated for nocturnal emissions caused by fire

It is contraindicated for patients with damp-heat or externally-contracted disorders.

Review questions

- Properties, actions and indications
- What herbs calm the liver and anchor yang?
- Which form is used for leakage of fluids?
- How is Long Gu prepared in decoction form?

Nourishing Herbs that Calm the Shen**Suān Zǎo Rén 酸枣仁**

- *Semen Zizyphi Spinosae*
- English: sour jujube seed, zizyphus
- Properties: sweet, sour, neutral
- Channels: Heart, Liver

Actions and Indications

Actions: Nourishes the Heart yin, augments the Liver blood, and quiets the spirit.

Indications: for irritability, insomnia, and palpitations with anxiety due to either blood deficiency or yin deficiency

Shen disturbance due to liver yin deficiency with deficient heat: Zhi Mu, Fu Ling (suan zao ren tang)

Shen disturbance due to heart and kidney deficiency: Sheng Di, Xuan Shen, Dang Gui, Bai Zi Ren

Actions: Prevents abnormal sweating; mild astringent to stop sweating

Indications: for both spontaneous sweating and night sweats: Dang Shen, Wu Wei Zi, Shan Zhu Yu

Main Actions:

- Nourishes the heart and liver and calms Shen
- Prevents sweating

Dosage: 10-30 grams in decoction. Crush before decocting to increase the extraction of active constituents. As powder, take 1.5-3 grams before bedtime.

Unprocessed Suan Zao Ren is cooler and better for insomnia with heat signs. The dry-fried form is warmer and better for calming the Shen and relieving insomnia.

Cautions:

Suan Zao Ren is contraindicated in patients with insomnia caused by excess heat or by hot phlegm accumulation.

Use with caution for patients who have diarrhea or an exterior condition.

Use of this herb may be associated with drowsiness and sedation.

It should be used with caution during pregnancy, as it stimulates contraction of the uterus.

Review questions

- Actions and indications
- For what kind of insomnia is this herb used?
- What herb calms the Shen and prevents sweating?
- How is it prepared in decoction?
- When should it be taken in powder form for insomnia?

Bǎi Zǐ Rén 白子仁

- *Semen Biotae Orientalis*
- English: arbor-vitae seed, biota seed
- Properties: sweet, neutral
- Channels: Heart, Large Intestine, Kidney

Actions and Indications**Actions: Nourishes the Heart and calms the spirit.****Indications:** for irritability, insomnia, forgetfulness, and palpitations with anxiety due to Heart blood deficiency

- Bai Zi Ren is similar to Suan Zao Ren. Both nourish the heart and calm the Shen.
- Insomnia due to heart blood deficiency with palpitations, dizziness and forgetfulness: Suan Zao Ren, Wu Wei Zi, Fu Shen
- Insomnia with night sweats: Ren Shen, Wu Wei Zi, Mu Li

Actions: Moistens the intestines and unblocks the bowels.**Indications:** for constipation in the elderly, anemic, or postpartum women due to blood or yin deficiency. It is often combined with other seed-type herbs.**Main Actions**

- Nourishes the heart and calms the Shen
- Moistens the intestines and unblocks the bowels

Dosage: 10-18 grams. Crush Bai Zi Ren seeds before decocting to facilitate the extraction of active constituents.**Cautions:** Bai Zi Ren should be used with caution for patients with loose stools or excess phlegm.**Review questions**

- Name two seed-type herbs which tonify the heart and calm the Shen.
- What herb moistens the intestines and unblocks the bowels?

Yuǎn Zhì 远志

- *Radix Polygalae Tenuifoliae*
- English: Chinese senega root, polygala
- Properties: bitter, acrid, slightly warm
- Channels: Heart, Lung

Actions and Indications**Actions: Pacifies the heart and calms the shen (spirit):****Indications:** for insomnia, palpitations with anxiety, restlessness and disorientation.

(Shi-excess) Zhu Sha, Long Gu (formula: Yuan zhi wan)

(Xu-deficient) Ren Shen, Shi Chang Pu (formula: Bu wan san)

Actions: Expels phlegm and clears the orifices**Indications:** used when phlegm obstructs the heart and orifices, with such manifestations as emotional and mental disorientation or seizures**Actions: Expels phlegm from the Lungs****Indications:** for cough with copious sputum, especially when it is difficult to expectorate: Xing Ren, Jie Geng, Gan Cao

Actions: Reduces abscesses and dissipates swellings

Indications: for boils, abscesses, sores, and swollen, painful breasts. Yuan Zhi can be used internally and applied topically.

Main Actions:

- Pacifies the heart and calms the Shen
- Expels phlegm and clears the orifices
- Reduces abscesses and dissipates swellings

Dosage: 3-10 grams. Unprocessed Yuan Zhi strongly dispels phlegm and opens the orifices. Honey-processed herb more effectively calms the Shen and tranquilizes the mind.

Cautions:

Because Yuan Zhi is drying in nature, use it with caution in patients experiencing heat symptoms or hot phlegm.

Use Yuan Zhi with caution in patients who have gastritis, peptic or duodenal ulcers. Gan Cao can be added to ease the irritating effect Yuan Zhi has on the stomach and to prevent nausea and vomiting.

Review questions

- Actions and indications
- What herb calms the Shen, expels phlegm and clears the orifices?

Hé Huān Pí 合欢皮

- *Cortex Albizziae Julibrissin*
- English: mimosa tree bark, albizzia
- Properties: sweet, neutral
- Channels: Heart, Liver

Actions and Indications**Actions: Calms the Shen (spirit) and relieves constraint**

Indications: for short temper, depression, insomnia, irritability, premenstrual syndrome and forgetfulness due to liver qi stagnation.

Actions: Invigorates the blood, alleviates pain, and dissipates swellings

Indications: for pain and swelling due to traumatic injury, including bone fractures; also, for internal abscesses or carbuncles due to blood stasis.

- Emotional disturbance: Suan Zao Ren, Bai Zi Ren, Long Gu
- Traumatic injury: Dang Gui, Da Huang, Zhi Zi
- Lung abscess: Yu Xing Cao, Lu Gen, Dong Gua Zi

Main Actions:

- Calms the Shen and relieves constraint
- Invigorates blood and reduces swelling

Dosage: 10-15 grams

Review questions:

- What herb is especially good for depression?
- Properties: sweet, neutral
- Actions: calm the Shen, relieve constraint
- Indications: depression, irritability, insomnia, and forgetfulness.

Yè Jiāo Téng 夜交藤

“vine of the night” “vine to pass through the night”

- *Caulis Polygoni Multiflori*
- English: polygonum vine
- Properties: slightly bitter, neutral
- Channels: Heart, Liver

Actions and Indications

Actions: Nourishes the heart and calms the shen (spirit)

Indications: for heart blood deficiency leading to sleep disorders such as insomnia, difficulty falling asleep or staying asleep and excessive dreams.

Actions: Opens the channels and collaterals and dispels wind.

Indications: for Bi syndromes. Decoction can be used as topical wash in treating eczema, rash and itchy skin.

Main Actions:

- Nourishes the heart and calms the Shen
- Opens the channels and collaterals and dispels wind

Dosage: 15-30 grams in decoction.

Review question

- What herbs nourish the heart and calm the Shen?